



Minoan women

This detail taken from one of the stunning, brightly colored wall paintings at Knossos, shows a trio of refined Minoan ladies with attractively dressed hair, wearing fashionable clothes that left them exposed to the waist. There is evidence that Minoan women took a significant lead in many aspects of life.

Some scholars think that these main cities resembled small city-states (see pp.94–95), each ruling a specific part of the island and with a focus on trade. Minoan palaces themselves were vast sumptuous complexes with well-lit

1,000 The number of rooms thought to make up the famous frescoed palace at Knossos, “capital city” of the Minoan civilization.

rooms arranged around internal courtyards. The palaces had advanced drainage systems, similar to those in the Indus Valley (see p.58–59), and plumbing that featured interlocking clay pipes and flushing toilets.

A culture of craftspeople

Courtiers and wealthy families living in villas surrounding the palace would have owned exquisite artifacts and

Knossos palace

Around 1700 BCE, the Knossos palace complex was destroyed by an earthquake or an invasion. When rebuilt, the palace was even more splendid, with stone steps linking the different buildings on its hilly site.



gold jewelry for which the Minoans were famed. A distinctive feature of Minoan culture was its “Kamáres ware” pottery—including cups, jugs, jars, and enormous urns (*pithoi*), used to store food—with stylized designs often painted in black, white, and red.

Evidence suggests that many ordinary Minoans worked as craftspeople, making items for home use and export. The wealth that this industry created meant that they, too, lived in relatively



Bull-leaping

A Knossos palace fresco reveals the perilous art of bull-leaping in which young men and women took turns somersaulting over a bull's back.

sophisticated, multi-roomed houses. Those that did not follow a craft worked the land, providing for the cities that powered Cretan society; tasks would have included tending the vines and olive trees that produced large quantities of wine and oil.

Mythology and religion

Excavated artifacts give us an insight into Minoan religious practices and beliefs. People appear to have been buried with possessions or offerings, showing a belief in an afterlife. Cretan vases and frescoes are suffused with imagery featuring bulls, axes, snakes, and goddesses. All Minoan gods were female and one of the most popular was the “Snake Goddess,” depictions of whom have been found in the ruins of houses and small palace shrines.

The bull image is widespread, being linked to King Minos. According to legend, his failure to sacrifice a bull sent by the sea-god Poseidon caused Minos' wife to give birth to the Minotaur—a creature that was half-man, half-bull. Minos trapped the Minotaur in a labyrinth, and young people were sacrificed to the creature every year.

Cretan frescoes also show young men and women leaping over bulls, which may have been performed for sport or for religious purposes.

Women in Minoan society

Women played an equal role to that of men in Minoan society, and participated in all occupations and trades, including the priesthood. Female “bull-leapers” are depicted alongside the men, and there is even evidence to suggest that Minoan society might have been “matrilineal” (with inheritance passed down the female line).



Dolphin fresco

This beautiful fresco was discovered in a palace throne room. The Minoans moved from a decorative artistic style in their early days to the naturalistic style of art seen here.

HOW WE KNOW

THE LOST CITY

In around 1600 BCE, the Santorini islands, near Crete, experienced a huge volcanic eruption. Near the modern city of Akrotiri, on the island of Thera, archaeologists have unearthed a sophisticated, Minoan-style city of town houses, frescoes, and fine pottery, frozen in time beneath 200ft (60m) of ash and pumice. The eruption has been linked with the “lost city” of Plato's Atlantis, the Bible story of the ten plagues visited upon Egypt, and the decline of Minoan civilization.



AFTER

The rich and highly successful Minoan civilization started to wane around 1500 BCE, but its complete decline took hundreds of years.

VOLCANIC ERUPTION

The **Thera eruption** in 1600 BCE (see above) may have resulted in the loss of the Cretan fleet, making Crete more vulnerable to outside powers and influence. Trade networks may also have been wiped out, causing “ripple-effect” damage throughout the whole region.

ARRIVAL OF THE MYCENAEANS

By 1500 BCE, the **Mycenaeans**, a late Bronze Age people from mainland Greece, had arrived on Crete. The Minoan and Mycenaean cultures had already influenced each other through trade. However, by 1400 BCE, the Mycenaeans **dominated Crete and the Aegean**. Their takeover may have been aided by an **earthquake** on Crete in the 1400s, which partially destroyed some Minoan cities.

JOINT DECLINE

The Mycenaeans adopted much Minoan culture, and a wonderful fusion of Minoan–Mycenaean styles flourished during this period. However, by 1200 BCE, the Cretan palace-cities were in decline **78–79** >>, and the **Greek Dorian** people moved in. The increasing use of iron for tools and weapons, and in trade, may also have put the Bronze Age culture at a disadvantage, and have been a factor in the civilization's decline.